
RESEARCH PAPER

Ireland's Layered Security Cooperation Model

How bilateral, EU, and NATO-adjacent cooperation tracks compound rather than compete—the institutional mechanics, the friction points, and the conditions under which this model is replicable for non-aligned EU member states.

Security Ireland

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THE ARGUMENT

The conventional framing treats bilateral UK–Ireland cooperation and EU defence integration as alternatives. This framing is analytically wrong and politically dangerous as the tracks are not alternatives, they are layers in a single architecture where capability built in one track feeds into the others.

This paper provides three things the existing analysis lacks. First, the institutional mechanics: exactly how capability transfers between tracks—which data, through which protocols, processed by which agencies, under what classification constraints. Second, the friction points: where the tracks actually rub against each other and what institutional design can manage the friction without eliminating it. Third, the replicability conditions: what makes this model work for Ireland specifically, and under what conditions it could work for other non-aligned EU members—with Austria as both a parallel case and a cautionary tale.

The model

Ireland's security cooperation operates across three simultaneous tracks:

The EU track includes seven PESCO projects as full member (Maritime Surveillance Upgrade, Maritime Mine Countermeasures, Critical Seabed Infrastructure Protection, Cyber Threats and Incident Response, Network of Logistic Hubs, plus two further projects), CISE membership for maritime data sharing since April 2025, and approximately €350 million committed to the European Peace Facility.

The bilateral track includes the Cork MoU signed March 2026 covering maritime, cyber, air domain, subsea, exercises, procurement, and training; the Subsea

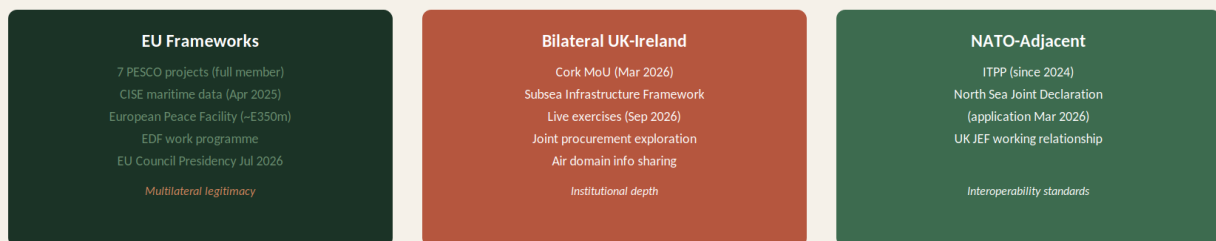
Infrastructure Framework for cable incident coordination; and joint exercises committed for September 2026.

The NATO-adjacent track includes the Individually Tailored Partnership Programme joined in 2024, the North Sea Joint Declaration application of March 2026, and a working relationship with the UK Joint Expeditionary Force.

The analytical claim is not simply that these tracks coexist, it is that they compound. Capability built through bilateral cooperation with the UK feeds directly into Ireland's EU framework participation. This feeding mechanism is specific and traceable, not metaphorical, and understanding how it works—and where it breaks down—is essential to making the model sustainable.

Ireland's Three Cooperation Tracks

Not competing. Layered. Each feeds capability into the others.



The bilateral track builds institutional capacity that makes the EU track credible.

Source: Security Ireland analysis based on PESCO project data, Cork Summit outcomes, NATO ITPP documentation.

Figure 1: Three cooperation tracks. EU frameworks, bilateral UK–Ireland, and NATO-adjacent. Each feeds capability into the others. The bilateral track builds institutional depth that makes EU participation credible rather than symbolic.

The institutional mechanics of capability transfer

Maritime surveillance: from bilateral patrols to CISE data.

The Cork MoU's maritime track establishes naval liaison and coordinated patrol operations between Irish and Royal Navy vessels in the shared maritime approach. When Irish vessels conduct joint patrols with UK assets, the surveillance data generated—vessel tracking, anomaly detection, subsurface acoustic data—feeds into the Irish Defence Forces' operational picture. Since April 2025, Ireland has been a CISE participant, meaning this data can be shared into the EU's Common Information Sharing Environment for maritime surveillance.

The transfer is not automatic; it passes through several institutional filters.

First, the classification constraint: data generated from joint UK patrols may carry UK classification markings that are not automatically shareable into EU systems. The UK–EU security of information agreement governs what can be shared, but the practical protocols for downgrading or sanitising UK-origin maritime data for CISE ingestion do not yet exist. This is a solvable problem, but it requires explicit protocol development—something the September 2026 exercises should test.

Second, the format constraint: UK maritime surveillance systems use different data standards than CISE's interoperability framework. Data reformatting requires dedicated integration capability within the Irish Defence Forces that does not currently exist at scale.

Subsea infrastructure: from bilateral framework to PESCO project. The Subsea Infrastructure Framework establishes coordinated response protocols for cable incidents in waters shared by Ireland and the UK. This operational protocol directly strengthens Ireland's contribution to the PESCO Critical Seabed Infrastructure Protection project. The friction point is governance asymmetry. The PESCO project operates under EU governance with reporting obligations to the EDA and EEAS. The bilateral Subsea Framework operates under the Cork MoU's bilateral governance. When an incident occurs in waters simultaneously covered by both frameworks, which governance takes precedence? The answer must be operational, not political: the nearest capable asset responds first, and governance alignment happens after the incident. But this operational logic must be codified in advance.

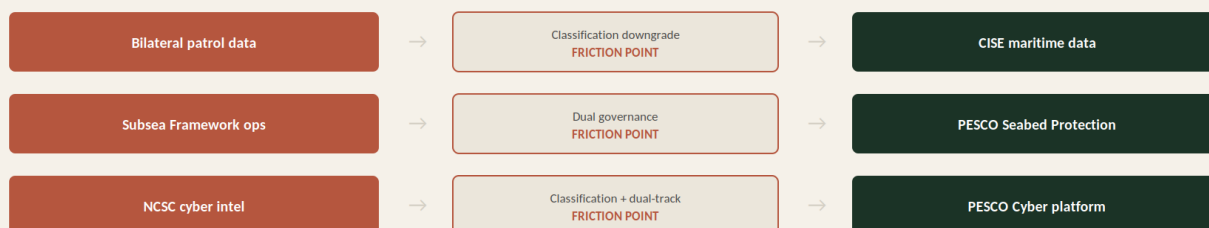
Cyber: from bilateral threat sharing to PESCO platform.

The Cork MoU's cyber cooperation track establishes NCSC-to-NCSC threat intelligence sharing. Threat indicators, malware signatures, and incident response lessons flow bilaterally in close to real time. This bilateral intelligence strengthens Ireland's contribution to the PESCO Cyber Threats and Incident Response project. The classification

friction is most acute in the cyber domain. UK-origin cyber threat intelligence is often classified at levels that require specific bilateral handling agreements. Ireland's NCSC must develop the institutional capacity to manage dual-track reporting: bilaterally sharing detailed indicators with the UK while sharing processed analysis with PESCO partners.

Capability Flows: From Bilateral Inputs to EU Outputs

Each flow has specific institutional mechanics – and specific friction points



Source: Security Ireland analysis. Friction points are the specific institutional constraints the September 2026 exercises should test.

Figure 2: Capability flows from bilateral inputs to EU outputs. Each flow has specific institutional mechanics—and specific friction points where classification, governance, and format constraints must be managed.

The Cork MoU: anatomy and gaps

The Cork MoU covers seven domains: maritime, cyber defence, air domain information sharing, subsea infrastructure, joint exercises, joint procurement, and personnel/training exchanges. The design is deliberate: every domain maps to an existing PESCO project or EU framework. This alignment was not accidental—Ireland's PESCO project selections were made precisely because they address the shared UK–Ireland security domain.

But the MoU has three operational gaps that must be closed.

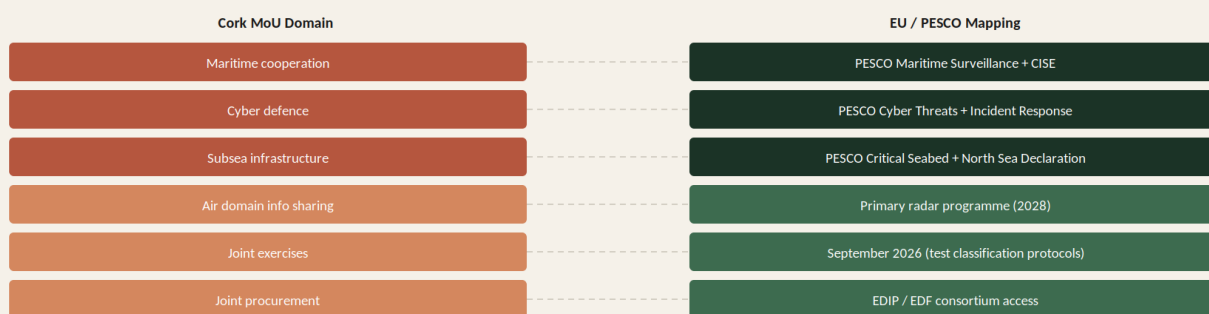
The air domain gap. The MoU commits to 'air domain information sharing' but does not address the elephant in the room—the secret RAF air intercept arrangement under which British fighters respond to unidentified aircraft in Irish airspace. The MoU formalises information sharing but not the operational dependency. Until Ireland has primary radar (target 2028) and some form of air response capability, the bilateral air domain cooperation is structurally asymmetric.

The implementation gap. The MoU creates governance commitments at the London–Dublin level but has no mechanism for coordinating island-level operations. Subsea cables land on coasts in both jurisdictions, and the energy grid is coupled across the border. Maritime domain awareness in the Irish Sea involves assets from Cork, Belfast, and Plymouth. But who coordinates the cross-border dimensions? This is the subject of the companion working paper—*The GFA and the Security Gap*—and the accompanying paper: *North/South Security Implementation Protocol*.

The procurement gap. The MoU commits to 'exploring joint procurement' but does not specify which platforms, under what terms, or through which frameworks. Joint procurement with a non-EU state requires careful alignment with EU procurement rules—particularly if Ireland simultaneously participates in EDIP consortia that have EU co-funding.

The Cork MoU: Seven Domains, Seven EU Mappings

Every bilateral domain maps to an existing PESCO project or EU framework. This alignment was deliberate.



Source: Security Ireland analysis based on Cork Summit communiqué, PESCO project database.

Figure 3: The Cork MoU's seven cooperation domains, each mapping to a PESCO project or EU framework. The bilateral architecture was deliberately designed to complement EU commitments.

The Austrian cautionary tale

Austria provides both a parallel case and a warning. Like Ireland, Austria is an EU member, constitutionally neutral, and not a NATO member. Austria participates in PESCO with four projects: a cyber security programme with Greece, a disaster-response programme led by Italy, a military transport initiative, and the German-led centre for training missions. Austria also participates in EU battlegroups and maintains a framework nation relationship with Germany.

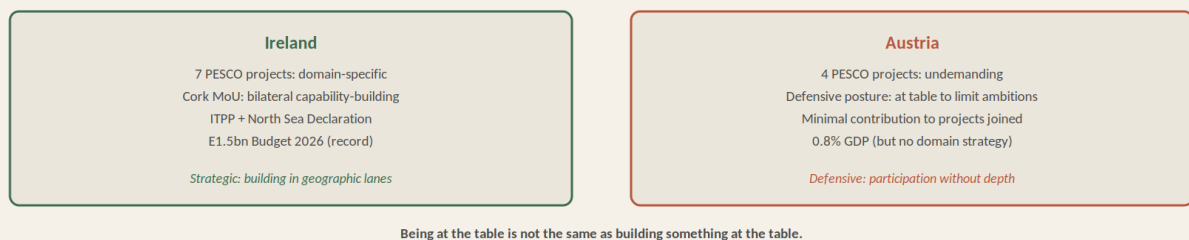
But Austria's approach to PESCO has been defensive, not strategic. As the European Council on Foreign Relations has observed, Austrian political elites—regardless of political orientation—have been primarily interested in engaging with EU defence structures to limit their ambitions,

ensuring Austria is at the table to block escalation rather than to build capability. Austria joined PESCO eagerly, but chose undemanding projects and contributed minimally. The result is participation that provides political cover without institutional depth.

Ireland risks the same outcome if layered cooperation remains at the governance level without generating operational capability. Seven PESCO projects on paper means nothing if those projects do not produce deployed capability that feeds into Ireland's maritime, subsea, and cyber domains. The Cork MoU is a framework, not a capability. The September 2026 exercises are a beginning, not a system reform.

Ireland and Austria: Structurally Parallel, Strategically Divergent

Austria joined PESCO defensively. Ireland has a chance to do it differently.



Being at the table is not the same as building something at the table.

Source: Security Ireland analysis based on ECFR analysis of neutral state PESCO participation.

Figure 4: Ireland and Austria—structurally parallel, strategically divergent. Austria joined PESCO defensively. Ireland has a chance to do it differently: choosing domain-specific projects that build real capability in its geographic lanes.

The September 2026 exercises as design problem

The joint exercises committed at Cork for September 2026 are the first opportunity to test whether the layered model generates operational capability or remains a governance exercise. What is tested matters as much as whether the exercises succeed. The exercises should test five things:

(1) Classification transfer protocols. Can maritime surveillance data generated from joint UK–Ireland patrols be processed and shared into CISE within operational timelines? If it takes weeks to clear data for CISE ingestion, the data is operationally useless.

(2) Dual-governance incident response. When a subsea cable incident occurs in waters covered by both the bilateral Subsea Framework and the PESCO Critical Seabed Infrastructure Protection project, which governance activates first? The exercise should simulate a cable incident and test whether the response protocols can operate under dual governance without conflicting instructions.

(3) Cyber dual-track reporting. Can Ireland's NCSC simultaneously share detailed threat indicators bilaterally with UK NCSC and processed analysis with PESCO Cyber Threats partners? This tests the institutional capacity for managing classified information across two channels with different classification regimes.

(3) Air domain asymmetry. How does air domain information sharing work when one partner has no independent detection capability? The exercise should test the information flow from UK radar coverage into Irish operational awareness—and identify what changes when Irish primary radar becomes operational in 2028.

(4) Cross-border coordination. Can island-level agencies in both jurisdictions coordinate a response to a simultaneous maritime and energy infrastructure incident without ad hoc improvisation? This tests whether standing coordination mechanisms exist at the implementation layer—or whether every incident requires governance-level intervention.

Three Implementation Layers

Governance is established. Interface exists. The implementation layer is the gap the exercises should audit.



Source: Security Ireland analysis. See The GFA and the Security Gap for the implementation layer architecture.

Figure 5: Three implementation layers. Governance (state-to-state): established through Cork MoU and PESCO. Interface (NI as strategic node): identified analytically. Implementation (who coordinates island-level operations): the gap the exercises should audit.

Conditions for replicability

The layered cooperation model is replicable under five conditions:

(1) Geographic domain relevance. The state must occupy a geographic or institutional position that creates a specific security domain where its contribution is irreplaceable. Ireland has the Atlantic EEZ and the cable terminus. Austria has the Alpine transit corridor and the Balkan proximity.

(2) An existing bilateral partner. The state must have a bilateral security relationship with a partner whose capabilities complement its own and whose cooperation does not undermine EU commitments. Ireland has the UK. Austria has Germany.

(3) EU framework access. The state must participate in PESCO and have access to EU funding instruments (EDF,

EDIP, SAFE). This provides the multilateral legitimacy that bilateral cooperation alone cannot generate.

(4) NATO-adjacent engagement. Some form of engagement with NATO structures provides interoperability standards and multilateral reach that EU frameworks alone do not cover.

(5) Political capacity for the constitutional distinction. The state's political system must be capable of distinguishing between non-alignment (a diplomatic posture) and security cooperation (an operational necessity). If the political system conflates these—treating any cooperation as a step toward alliance membership—the model cannot operate. Ireland's McEntee formulation ('not neutral to threats') demonstrates this capacity. Austria's defensive PESCO posture suggests it may not.

The Real Risk: Neither Track Alone Is Sufficient

The model works only if both tracks generate institutional depth and are connected through a functioning implementation layer.



The September 2026 exercises are the first test. If they produce a friction audit, the model is validated.

Source: Security Ireland analysis

Figure 6: Neither track generates sufficient depth alone. The layered model works only if both tracks generate institutional depth—and are connected through a functioning implementation layer.

Ireland's layered security cooperation model is analytically sound and practically validated by the Cork MoU, but it is not self-sustaining. The model works only if bilateral cooperation generates actual operational capability, EU

participation produces institutional depth, and an implementation layer connects governance commitments to the island-level systems they are supposed to protect.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Austria shows what happens when a non-aligned state joins EU defence structures defensively: participation without depth or capability. Ireland has a six-month window during its EU Presidency to demonstrate the opposite. The September 2026 exercises are the first test. If they produce a friction audit that identifies specific, solvable coordination gaps, the model is validated. If they produce nothing but photographs, the model is governance theatre.

SERIES CONTEXT

This paper extends the analysis in the foundational working papers (The UK–Ireland Security Interface and The GFA and the Security Gap) by providing the institutional mechanics of capability transfer between tracks, the operational friction points, and the replicability conditions. It draws on the Austrian comparison from ECFR’s analysis of neutral state PESCO participation, and on the operational detail of CISE, the Subsea Infrastructure Framework, and NCSC bilateral cooperation.

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